2009 to $92 billion in 2019 (the comparable figures for India–China trade are $41 billion and $84 billion in 2019).[42]

Most importantly, India engaged the US in a range of diplomatic initiatives. With Washington, it issued a statement on protecting maritime access in the South China Sea. It also brandished a 'US-India Joint Strategic Vision for the Asia-Pacific and Indian Ocean Region'. When the Americans proposed a Free and Open Indo-Pacific (FOIP) in 2017 to counter China's growing influence in Asia, India became a member of the group along with Australia and Japan. It joined the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue – or 'Quad' – in November 2017 which includes Australia, Japan, and the US. The Quad is the military–defence counterpart of the FOIP. In 2020, India and the US signed a Global Comprehensive Strategic Partnership which was largely a restatement of many of the ideas and initiatives that had brought them together over the past several years. Though they coyly refused to name it in these various initiatives, China was the object of their common concern.

India and Russia charted a different course in the shadow of Chinese power: largely transactional–commercial to strengthen India's military and energy access. Russia was above all a source of arms: air defence systems, helicopters, fighter aircraft, tanks, and a range of naval vessels including nuclear-powered submarines. India increasingly insisted on transfer of technology, modernization of existing equipment, purchase of cutting-edge weaponry, and joint R&D. While Russia's share of arms exports to India dropped, it still supplied roughly 60 per cent of its weapons.[43] India also turned to Russia for energy. After the India–US nuclear deal in 2005, which resumed international cooperation with the Indian civilian nuclear programme, it was Moscow that signed most of the contracts. In addition, India bought Russian natural gas and invested in oil and gas fields in Russia. While the relationship was largely transactional, India was also attempting to diversify Russia's foreign policy options away from China. As part of weaning Moscow from Beijing, India held a growing number of military exercises, dialogues between service chiefs, and high-level meetings with Russian officials.